PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Panic of 1873 — A House Divided

How a Crash Helped End Reconstruction

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Panic of 1873 — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. The biggest causes aren't always the obvious ones. Trace this one carefully

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE · 1873 — A run on the banks



"The Panic — Run on the Fourth National Bank, New York, 1873" — wood engraving, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE · THE CHAIN OF EVENTS — From Wall Street to the South

> *Overbuilt railroads → the failure of Jay Cooke & Co. (Sept. 1873) → stock market closes, thousands of businesses fail, mass unemployment → Northern voters focus on the economy → in 1874, Democrats win control of the House → support for enforcing Reconstruction collapses.*
> *— summarized from the historical record. Public domain*

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YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · THE CRASH

In your own words, what caused the Panic of 1873, and how bad did the depression get?

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · THE CONNECTION

How did the depression weaken support for Reconstruction in the North?

- ☐ A. it made the North richer and more generous
- ☐ B. worried about jobs and banks, Northern voters lost interest in enforcing rights in the South
- ☐ C. it had no effect on politics
- ☐ D. it strengthened the Republicans

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · THE 1874 ELECTION

In 1874, angry voters handed Democrats control of the House. Why was this such a serious blow to Reconstruction?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · SURPRISING CAUSES

The Panic of 1873 had "nothing to do with race," yet it helped doom Reconstruction. In three or four sentences, explain what this teaches about how historical causes work — and why we must look beyond the obvious.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Panic of 1873 — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The Panic was caused by…; the depression was so bad that…"

QUESTION 2: **Correct — B. worried about jobs and banks, Northern voters lost interest in enforcing rights in the South**

Right. Facing unemployment and failing banks, Northern voters focused on their own economic survival and lost interest in enforcing Black rights far away in the South.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "Democratic control of the House mattered because…"

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "This shows that causes of great events…"